

Primary Source Reading 2: Not Merely a Pilot in a Vessel

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From René Descartes, Meditations on First Philosophy, Meditation VI, translated by John Veitch (1901) Read before Lesson 10b: Substance Dualism

Before you read: Descartes has just argued that mind and body are two genuinely distinct substances. But he immediately notices something that complicates this picture: his own experience does not feel like two separate things briefly cooperating. It feels like one thing. As you read, watch for the analogy he reaches for, and notice that he explicitly rejects it — this is Descartes himself flagging the problem that Lesson 10b will spend most of its time on.

What Pain Would Be Like If the Mind Merely Occupied the Body

Nature likewise teaches me by these sensations of pain, hunger, thirst, etc., that I am not only lodged in my body as a pilot in a vessel, but that I am besides so intimately conjoined, and as it were intermixed with it, that my mind and body compose a certain unity. For if this were not the case, I should not feel pain when my body is hurt, seeing I am merely a thinking thing, but should perceive the wound by the understanding alone, just as a pilot perceives by sight when any part of his vessel is damaged; and when my body has need of food or drink, I should have a clear knowledge of this, and not be made aware of it by the confused sensations of hunger and thirst: for, in truth, all these sensations of hunger, thirst, pain, etc., are nothing more than certain confused modes of thinking, arising from the union and apparent fusion of mind and body.

The Body's Effects on the Mind

Besides this, nature teaches me that my own body is surrounded by many other bodies, some of which I have to seek after, and others to shun. And indeed, as I perceive different sorts of colors, sounds, odors, tastes, heat, hardness, etc., I safely conclude that there are in the bodies from which the diverse perceptions of the senses proceed, certain varieties corresponding to them, although, perhaps, not in reality like them; and since, among these diverse perceptions of the senses, some are agreeable, and others disagreeable, there can be no doubt that my body, or rather my entire self, in as far as I am composed of body and mind, may be variously affected, both beneficially and hurtfully, by surrounding bodies.

After you read: Read these two passages next to Reading 1 and the tension should be obvious. Descartes has proven, to his own satisfaction, that mind and body are two distinct substances, each able to exist without the other. But he also insists that his experience of pain is not the experience of a pilot receiving a damage report from a ship he merely occupies — it is

something felt as *his own*, arising from a genuine union. He wants both claims at once: real distinctness, and real union. The lesson calls this the interaction problem, and you can see from these two readings that Descartes did not stumble into it by accident. He noticed the tension himself and tried to hold both sides of it, without ever fully explaining how a non-physical mind and a physical body can be “intermixed” closely enough to feel pain, while remaining, in their essence, two entirely different kinds of thing.